Queen 101

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64600435.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Abner (OC), Bow, Accountant side character, Prince side character, tutor side character, mentions of the alliance - Character

Additional Tags:
Etiquette, Queenly Duties, Financial Issues, fiscal jargin, courtesy at court, Alternate timeline: Angella lives

Language:
English

Series:
Part 34 of Let's Talk About It

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-11 Words: 5,788 Chapters: 1/1

Queen 101

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64600435.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Abner (OC), Bow, Accountant side character, Prince side character, tutor side character, mentions of the alliance - Character

Additional Tags:
Etiquette, Queenly Duties, Financial Issues, fiscal jargin, courtesy at court, Alternate timeline: Angella lives

Language:
English

Series:
Part 34 of Let's Talk About It

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-11 Words: 5,788 Chapters: 1/1

Queen 101

by Friendlylycanthrope

Summary

Back from their honeymoon, the trio are thrown into the responsibilities that come with being a Queen.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Adora, Catra, and Glimmer returned to their home at Castle Brightmoon after their honeymoon feeling more refreshed and alive than ever before. The 10 days spent at paradise in each other's company was like a slice of heaven, but it was also comforting to see the familiar spires and waterfalls that they called home now.

Their homecoming was welcomed by friends and family who had taken care of things during their absence. They were first met by General Abner, saluting and at the ready for duty as the Queen's head of security and personal guard.

"Your Majesty," She greeted, handing Glimmer a pad. It was odd to hear her address Glimmer in that way, who was typically 'highness' as a princess, where 'Majesty' was typically reserved for Angella. But they would have to get used to it. "You each have several appointments today."

Glimmer nodded and looked over the schedule. Although they all shared the title of Queen, Glimmer was still the de facto leader since she had the title through birthright rather than marriage, like Adora and Catra.

"Ugh, already?" Catra leaned on Glimmer's head from behind to look over at the schedule. "Figures the work starts as soon as we land."

“What’s this one,” Adora asked, looking over it, “It says ‘etiquette tutor’ with my and Catra’s names next to it.”

Glimmer tapped it to pull up the details.

“Oh wow. Looks like you two have to go through queen class while I do a budget meeting.”

“What? That’s bull.” Catra protested. “We’re already married, what do we need to learn? And why don’t you have to come?”

Glimmer smirked and held the pad under her arm. “I had to learn all this royal etiquette stuff when I was growing up. How to be a princess and curtsey properly, and how to sip tea and stuff was all just a part of my education. Looks like you two have to sit through Madame Rosemary’s lessons now.” She stuck out her tongue at Catra, which went against all the training she had learned years ago, but they enjoyed being able to rib each other.

“It could be good to learn more high class etiquette things.” Adora added with a shrug. “I fumbled a lot when I joined the princess alliance. Wouldn’t want to make any mistakes now that we’re queens.” Catra was the smartest of the three, but Adora was always the most eager to learn new things, from skills to data sets; anything to help her prepare to be a better She-Ra. She was the first to write things down, or sign up to learn more.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Fine, I’ll go to your fancy lady class, but no promises.”

“You might reconsider,” Abner added, still dutifully to the side. “The three of you all have a meeting with foreign dignitaries this afternoon. They will be expecting the best refinement of their host.”

Glimmer looked at the pad again to confirm. “True, we want to do our best to honor guests. You two have refinement with Madame Rosemary while I go over budget with the council. Then the three of us will meet with the nobles later.”

Adora smiled “Can’t wait!”

“Don’t be so sure you can ace this, Adora.” Glimmer smirked at her overly competitive wife. “Madame Rosemary is old school. Her lessons are hard, and she leaves no room for anything BUT success.”

Her eyes sparkled. “That sounds like a challenge. I’m in.”

Catra smiled. This dork was going to look hilarious trying to get an A+ in social etiquette class. Now it was more interesting to her.

“Alright, then let's get started.”

****

Catra and Adora sat in school desks, feeling a bit of a throwback to their school days in the horde. They were waiting for their tutor to appear in the classroom, so they had some time to take in what Glimmer's education may have looked like in these same halls. Books and scrolls lined the shelves with every subject from history to science and the arts. A globe of Etheria had been left to gather dust under a poster that showed the orbital patterns of all the moons. At the front of the classroom was a long black chalkboard, covered in old smeared dust from what was previously erased, perhaps last used years ago.

"You know when you get down to it," Adora said looking around from her desk. "The details are not that different from classes in the Horde."

Catra scoffed. "Don't need a reminder of *those* . But they do have a lot more colors here." She had her feet propped up on the desk while she inspected her nails.

Catra did not expect to get much from this. She could pretend to learn in order to get the grade she needed to pass, but had no plan on following through with actually utilizing any etiquette. She would always be Catra, and nobody could tell her what to do or how to act. Nonetheless, Glimmer had made her promise that

they could not quit until they completed a full lesson, and not before.

Just then, the door slammed open and alarmed them both, and an elderly woman came in with a confident stride, books under her arm. Her bun was so tight behind her head, that Catra was amazed it hadn't pulled out all the wrinkles in her sour face. She was dressed in many layers of clothing, making her look even more uptight with no skin showing aside from her hands and her face, even her neck was covered in fancy laces.

"Now then, I am told that you two are my latest ladies in need of proper priming." She said sweetly, despite her more sinister look as she eyed them both over, no doubt evaluating all the flaws in their posture as they sat stiffly. "Ladies are by definition, gentle creatures. But rest assured, the road to becoming a lady is anything *but* gentle. Now, where is my yardstick?"

"Uh, this yardstick?" Adora pointed to her side where the long apparatus was up on the wall. "I don't know if it will work to measure anything, it looks like there's …blood ? on it…?" She said nervously. Perhaps this wouldn't be so different from the horde after all.

"No need to worry," Madame Rosemary said as she calmly collected it. "I won't use it for measuring."

Adora and Catra shared a nervous glance and swallowed nervously.

****

“Okay, what do we have?” Glimmer stepped into the war room where she would meet with her financial advisors. One one side of the table was Bow, ready with his college-level understanding of economics from his family. On the other side, the head of accounting.

Bow handed her a bound report that was thicker than his neck. “A lot of catching up to do, apparently.”

Glimmer frowned, taking the report in both hands and heaving it onto the table. “What is this, all the old records?” She flipped through dozens of pages with charts, graphs, and lines of text.

“I’m afraid not.” The chief accountant said and adjusted their glasses. “This is the data collection report from the last quarter.”

“You gotta be kidding!” Glimmer opened to a random page. There was a chart showing numbers changing slightly over time within fractions of a decimal along with paragraphs beneath which laid out the parameters of the data. “This is going to take years to get through, there’s thousands of pages!”

“Tens of thousands, actually.” The advisor added. “And not a page less. Every statistic reported is fully correct and just as important – nay, *essential* – to the report’s findings.”

“What was your name?” Glimmer asked. The advisor stood up and pushed their glasses up again.

“Dr. Arbor Sawyer, your majesty. Director of royal accounting services.”

“Right.” Glimmer sat down and shut the huge report. “Arbor, is there any way that we can just… find a simpler way to do this?” Glimmer grimaced with discomfort at the boring task ahead.

“Pardon me, your majesty.” Arbor smiled nervously and rubbed their neck. “But cutting corners in finance is a quick way to end up in a lot of trouble. I assure you, when the quarterly reports were presented to the former queen–”

“I’m not the former Queen.” Glimmer cut in. “My mother was wise and patient, and it served her term well. But it was my quick thinking and action that brought the war to an end. I want to be a different kind of queen than she was.”

Arbor looked to Bow for some signal of certainty. Bow shrugged.

“I know it's not the most glamorous job, Glim. Not the high-stakes action we usually face. But this is what the Queen does.”

Glimmer groaned “Look, just give it to me simple: are we in debt?”

“Well, in terms of–”

“Yes or no question: no beating around the bush, no technical terms, no jargon. Are we in the black?”

Arbor looked at the various scans and printouts of tables that they had prepared for the meeting, trying to find one word to summarize everything.

“Um… yes?” They scratched their chin. “Yes, we are in the black. For now. If we –”

“Great!” Glimmer smiled and threw her hands up. “Which means we have some budget to spend if we aren’t paying debts. So, what projects can we fund?”

“So glad you asked!” Bow lit up and clicked a button on the table, pulling up a slide show.

****

“Wrong again!” Madame Rosemary smacked the yardstick on the desk, making a sharp *SNAP* sound that startled both wives. “From the top!”

Adora sat perfectly upright, after a hard lesson on how to sit the “proper” way: back straight, hands folded neatly, legs slanted, eyes forward. She was eager to be a good soldier – or in this case, a good Queen– and prove that she could do this!

It would be easier if Catra wasn’t rubbing it in so much. But her wife was smugly perfect at everything on the first try! It did not take long for both of their more competitive nature to kick in, and the battle was ruthless. Catra had perfect balance and poise, Adora was better at memorizing the rules.

“Bad habits in the highest degree of displeasing!" Adora recited from memory. "To look steadily at anyone, especially if you are a lady and are speaking to a gentleman; to turn the head frequently on one side and the other during conversation; to bend forward; to strike your hands upon your knees; to hold one of your knees between your hands locked together; to cross your legs; to extend your feet on the andirons; to admire yourself with complacency in a glass; to remain without gloves; to fold carefully your shawl, instead of throwing it with graceful negligence upon a table!”

"Much better!" Madame Rosemary circled around the girls once again in checking their posture. "As queens, you must ensure to never accidentally commit one of these grievous faux pas. It would bring shame to the entire royal family!" She droned on more.

Catra took a free moment while the Madame had her back turned to make a stupid face at Adora. The recipient, infuriated, grumbled and glared at her wife. How dare she be so smug about it!

SNAP! The yardstick came down on the Madame's desk at the front again to earn their full attention.

"Adora, what did we say about mumbling! One must project and enunciate."

Adora sat even more upright than she was before, eyes ahead. No distractions! She needed that gold star to rub it in both her wives' faces so that she could TOTALLY be every inch a queen and a lady.

"Yes, Madame!" Adora said clearly. Replace 'Madame' with 'Sergeant' and it was just like school growing up in the Fright Zone.

Of course in the Horde, they were punished with more push ups or laps, not sore knuckles. Truth be told, she would prefer to do

some pushups right now to help with her anxious energy as she needed to please the superior.

"Good." Madame Rosemary nodded. "Now, for the next lesson. Stand up, and each of you place one of these books atop your head."

Catra smirked. It was her time to shine when it came to matters of balance. Having large ears she could move and help steady the book would help too. She gave Adora a shit eating grin, making the latter turn red. They were going to out-etiquette the HELL out of each other.

****

"Okay, so after adding in the grant for road repair from the merchant's guild, how much does that leave for the Veteran benefit packages for their retirement?" Glimmer asked, adding yet another grant in need of money onto the white board.

At first she wasn't so sure about this budget meeting stuff, but it was shaping up into something she could get behind! Once she knew that the kingdom had a set amount of disposable income to expend on betterment of infrastructure and livelihoods, it was all about helping people. And really, isn't that what it was all about?

Bow punched numbers into his calculator. “Uh. About 19 cents.” He frowned. “Per veteran… Before postage.”

Glimmer spun around to look at him incredulously. “What?!”

Bow shrugged and showed her the math. “We’re spread way too thin. We can’t fund *every* project that makes a request.”

By now, Arbor was in a stage of defeat in their grief journey for the budget meeting. They had their head down on the table on top of folded arms, hiding their face from the world.

How. How?? It was a simple task. It was just a meeting with the new Queen. Gathering all the data had been the hard part, making sense of it was another beast entirely. But now? The meeting had devolved into “How much can we spend to fix up the kingdom for our people” in ways that would certainly put them in centuries of debt.

They could see it all now: the headlines when the kingdom hit rock bottom. “ *Could this have been avoided?* ” Subheading: “ *common currency loses all value in the fair market.* ”

“That can’t be right.” Glimmer looked at the white board again. “Okay, maybe there are *some* things we can get rid of. Like I

really don’t want to budge on the farming grant, but maybe we don’t really NEED those surveillance drones….”

Arbor stifled a quiet sob. The military surveillance drones were the least of their worries right now.

****

“No, no, no!” Madame Rosemary shook her head. “Adora, you must not tip back your cup more than 90 degrees when you sip! It is unsightly, and rude!”

Adora put the teacup back on the table as delicately as she could. She really wanted to get every last drop of the tea, but she would have to hold back her usual appetite if it meant winning at Table Etiquette 101.

“And Catra, you must not reuse the same fork between courses.” Madame Rosemary continued. Catra put down the oyster knife on the plate, selecting the next one in line.

So far, they were evenly matched. It took all the strength they had to not openly gloat at the other, but speaking out of turn would be rude. They had gone over how to sit, how to wave, and

then how to dress had been particularly exhausting. And yet they still had to go over the basics of table manners. The sample lunch provided to them would cover all the essentials from cutlery to table conversation.

Adora and Catra narrowed their eyes over the table at each other. Sitting across from each other like this, they could finally see the look in the eye of their rival as they perfectly executed how to politely slice a piece of meat.

"Those who saw at their meat like wood," Madame Rosemary had scolded them, "Act like cavemen."

It turned out there were a lot of courses to cover in this fancy meal. In all honesty, the meal could have lasted for weeks, with tiny servings the size of a teaspoon artfully placed on each plate, and it would still only feed their competition.

"Why Catra, your majesty," Adora smiled leaning into the bit now of trying to impress their teacher. "How *absolutely marvelous* for you to appear at our esteemed home." She winked, pretending Catra were a foreign visitor.

"Oh why Lady Adora, your majesty," Catra leaned into the bit even harder, putting on a silly over-the-top accent. "How you *do* go on!"

They both laughed in the very rich, chortling way that the aristocrats in movies do. Heads thrown back to expose the throat

and all. As Adora did her fake laugh she lifted her silver fork to gesticulate wildly, but accidentally sent a piece of vegetable flying off the end. It ended its trajectory right in the face of their up tight tutor, which sobered up both queens in a heartbeat. The laughing cut short as they paled and stared in appalled anxiety, while Madame Rosemary tapped the yardstick in her hand, preparing for a good rap on the knuckles.

***

"This will definitely work!" Glimmer insisted. She looked over the message on her pad one more time, then hit *Send* . With one click, her request for help was sent out to all the alliance members who would know anything about balancing the books.

Glimmer sat back with her hands folded behind her head, looking pleased with herself. "Part of the Princess Alliance treaty means having financial clarity with our year end reports, right? So I'll just ask for these *public documents* from other kingdoms, and copy whatever strategy they did! Now all we have to do is wait."

"Um." Bow rubbed his neck. "Are you sure? The kingdoms are all *very* different, and not always compatible when it comes to cross-referencing strategies."

He looked over to Arbor for confirmation or assistance, but the director of accounting was still cleaning up the huge mess of papers they had made when trying to fund everything. THAT plan had clearly not worked out, and they wanted to eliminate any possibility of financial disaster.

"Chill out, Bow." Glimmer waved a hand with a confident smile, brushing the concern off. "This is fully legal. Financial transparency is a good thing! Besides, the other kingdoms have stable economies, so it can only get better." She assured him.

Her pad dinged with an incoming message and her face lit up.

"Ha! We already have a response with an attachment from Plumeria. Let's take a look here…" She opened up the file and began to read the summarized packet of instructions out loud.

"The goal is to enter a state of flow: allow the rhythm to guide revenue streams for inner peace. Step one: Each member should arrive in a state of mindful calm and financial clarity. Step two: gather your hand harps or other percussive instruments…?" Glimmer trailed off in confusion and scrolled through the document more as she skimmed. "Okay this is instructions for a meditative drum circle." She frowned.

Bow looked nervously at Arbor. Even Arbor stopped their tidying work to make a face of disbelief and concern. They almost managed to hide their cringe from the Queen.

Glimmer caught the look and could feel an ‘I told you’ coming on. She closed the document.

“Well, we all knew that Plumeria would have something healing and meditative in mind, right? Surely they won’t be the only response we get!” She laughed nervously. She looked to her pad as another ding went off.

“Ah perfect, the summary from Salineas!” She opened it up. “Ah, and this one is in video form.”

She pulled up the video on the table for all three of them to see clearly, and hit play. The video began to play, showing images of a large school of multicolored fish in a massive school, swirling around hypnotically. Most were silver, some were red or green or black or yellow, and a rare few were dark blue or purple. They bobbed around each other in a rhythmic pattern that only they could see, unpredictable and impossible to track. The three stared at it in confusion.

“Is… is it some sort of spell?” Glimmer squinted at the moving fish. “Or are the fish themselves the report?”

“Is this like… swimming towards or away from fiscal responsibility?” Bow asked, wondering if it was a metaphor, or perhaps a beautiful piece of moving art. He couldn’t peel his eyes away from the video.

Glimmer cringed, unsure WHAT exactly it was. But it made sense to the people of Salineas. She pulled the video down from the screen with a sigh of defeat.

"Okay, maybe the Salineas strategy isn't as straight forward as we hoped. But there's still –" Her pad dinged a third time and she smiled with a faint flicker of hope. "There's still Mystacor! Yes! Surely the wise elder mages and wizards have a sound strategy!" She opened it up. "NINE HUNDRED PAGES?!"

"That's bigger than our report is…" Arbor adjusted their glasses, feeling a bit shy about their report now.

Glimmer swallowed nervously.

"Mystacor has always been a beacon of wisdom and sagely advice. Surely they can't lead us wrong." She opened it up and began to read. "Money flows like a river, swift and free/ But its course must be guided, like wind on the sea/ If left unchecked, it will erode the land,/ Yet with careful direction, its power can expand…..wait a minute." She scrolled faster, skimming through dozens of pages. Her frown only grew.

Glimmer thumped her head slightly on the table with an annoyed groan.

"This is 300 pages of epic poetry about the philosophy of money…"

****

“Why are we in the throne room?” Catra asked. Madame Rosemary snapped her yardstick on the tile floor to get their attention.

“Remember, we speak to answer a question, not to find attention!” She reminded them both, and they each stood a bit straighter.

Ahead of them were the thrones that hovered in the air. Glimmer’s was in the middle. Catra and Adora’s were less tell but just as opulent, on either side. The room was empty, causing their voices to echo on the cavernously tall walls. Madame Rosemary turned to face them again.

“As Queens, it is necessary to address the people. To make announcements to your cabinet. To project one’s voice so it can ring clear as a bell, with no room for error!” Her voice echoed as she raised her voice slightly with enthusiasm for the last sentence. “As public figures, it falls to you to ensure that you enunciate CLEARLY so your words can never be used against you. And it will be in this very room, where we can train our acoustic ears! Now repeat after me: Your Majesty. Royal Protocol. Deference. First you, Adora.” She pointed with the stick.

Adora stood straight, perfecting her posture in the perfect queenly manner.

"Your Majesty. Royal Protocol. Deference." She repeated as clearly as she could.

Madame Rosemary nodded. "And you, Catra?"

Catra smirked, only half paying attention. At this point, being the best wasn't nearly as fun as getting under Adora's skin.

"Yooore MAJ-eh-stee." She over-pronounced. "RRRRRRoyàl prrrrr-OH-to-cOL…" She smirked and side eyed Adora, who was turning red. "Deh-FERR-ence!"

Madame Rosemary snapped the yardstick against Catra's feet, a light warning that made her jump, but didn't hurt yet.

"We are speaking with dignity. Not acting like buffoons!"

Now it was Adora's turn to smirk and side eye Catra, feeling more full of herself.

“Perhaps you two need a challenge.” Their tutor said sternly. “Repeat after me: The rapid rise of royal red roses rests upon the royal roadways. Adora, go.”

Adora suddenly went from smug to laser-focused, trying to not slip up.

“The rapid rise of royal red roses rests upon the royal roadways.” She enunciated perfectly.

“Separate your words better, do not rush through the sentence! Now you, Catra.”

Catra was clearly having way too much fun, and kept rolling her R’s and made more mock flourishes as though she were performing for a crowd.

“The rrrrAPid *rise* of rrRĔd rrRo-YÂLe rrrrõsES rrrrÈsststss upOOOONNNN the rrrrOYAle roooooaaaaad-waAAAAaays.” She even did a fancy bow.

Adora frowned, her brow furrowing as she tried to outdo the sentence.

“Theee rAAAAAPiiid riiiise of ROYAL reeeeed ROOOOses rEEEEESts upOOOOON the rOYAL RooooooadwaAAAAYS.”

“Now ladies–”

Catra turned more towards Adora with determination rather than facing their tutor at the front, eating up every second of this. “Theeeee RAAAAAApiiiiiiiiiiid RRRRIIIIIIIIIIIssssse ooooooof ROOOYYYYYaaaaaalllllll RED rOOOOOOses Reeeeeeessssssssssstssssss UUUUUUpooooon theeee ROOOOOOYYYYYYYaaaaaaalllllll ROOOOOAAAADWAAAAAAAAYS.”

“You Majesties, please!”

Adora narrowed her eyes and tried to say it again the most perfect as possible. “Theeeee RAĄĄĄĄApii~~iiiiiiii~~d RRRRIIIIIIIIIIIʃʃʃʃʃʃe ofƒƒƒ ŘŘOOOYYYYYaaaaaalllllll ŘŘŘEĐ rŌŌŌŌŌOOses ReeeeeeesŠŠŠŠŠŠssssstssss UUUUUUŕpooooon thɘɘɘee ROOOÖÖÖÖÖÖÖŶŶŶŶŶYYYYaaȧȧȧȧȧȧȧalllllll RöööööööööȦȦȦȦȦȦȦȦȦDWȦȦȦȦȦȦYS.”

“You are QUEENS, not JESTERS!” Madame Rosemary tried to regain order by knocking them both on the head with her yardstick. They both rubbed their heads with hunched shoulders. Both wanted to challenge the other to more and more challenging tongue twisters, but they were still in their lesson.

“I will not have a *verbal circus!”* She enunciated perfectly, with a stern look.

Catra smiled at the unique phrasing and immediately stole it for more use. “I bet you can’t say ‘Vivid vocalists ventured into the verbal circus, vexing every verse!’” Catra challenged Adora. And Adora, so caught up in the challenge with her rival, forgot that their instructor was still there shaking her head at them both.

It was too late, both of them were repeating the nonsensical phrase back and forth in more and more drama. Madame Rosemary clapped a palm to her forehead, still shaking back and forth with disappointment. “Gods help your royal court…”

****

Glimmer grumbled and stared at the ledgers like they were personally taunting her. Dryll had sent over blueprints for some sort of machine to solve the problem that they could not decipher. The Kingdom of Snows had sent them Frosta’s calculus homework by mistake. Spinnerella and Netossa still had not responded, leaving them on 'read.' Scorpia had responded in Morse code that Glimmer could not read, for privacy reasons.

She sighed in defeat– with great annoyance, but still an *annoyed* defeat. “Okay fine. No more shortcuts. We’ll do this the normal, boring, *bureaucratic* adult way!” She threw her hands up in frustration.

“Oh, thank you!” Arbor fell to their knees and grovelled at the Queen’s feet, clasping her hand with tears in their eyes. “Thank you, your Majesty, thank you!”

Confused, Glimmer pulled away her hand and helped them find a seat “Just walk me through the giant report.”

Bow smiled. He knew she would find the right thing eventually. He was still watching his beautiful fish video. It was just so calming!

“Your Majesty,” Arbor said with a curt nod. “We’ve prepared a summary of the upcoming quarter’s primary fiscal vectors, along with proposed redistributions across civic development, military training, and magical research.”

Bow whispered, “They made a color-coded budget pyramid,” like he was both impressed and mildly frightened.

Glimmer took a breath, squared her shoulders, and cracked open the ledger. “Alright. Show me the pyramid.”

Two hours and a few pots of tea later, they were both pouring over the math and columns with a rhythm of their own. It was far from thrilling, but it needed to be done. Glimmer was oddly focused – not with interest, but more like she was cleaning out a magical closet and found a forgotten item sort of way.

Arbor cut through items with ruthless efficiency. Bow translated the numbers into what it would look like in real-world impact. And slowly, *painfully* , the moving parts started to connect.

"Can we circle back on the projected expenditure curve?" Glimmer asked, looking through the lines of her notes. "We'll need to account for soft costs versus hard costs. There's a nontrivial deviation in the projected arcane maintenance fees."

"We could try to frontload the allocation but adjust the glide path over Q3?" Arbor suggested.

"Right." Bow nodded. " *IF* we don't hit any unplanned expenditure spikes from magical maintenance."

"And if we do?" Glimmer asked.

Arbor didn't even blink. "Then we dip into the mystical contingency reserve. That's what it's for."

Glimmer nodded her approval, then looked over the scattered papers and notes again. "Wait… it actually works?"

"You did the work," Bow said, grinning. "You made it work."

She leaned back in her chair, groaning softly and rubbing her face. “Ugh. Don’t say it like that. I’ll start feeling responsible.”

Arbor cleared their throat. “Would Her Majesty like to sign off on the proposed allocations?”

“Her Majesty,” Glimmer muttered, grabbing the quill, “Still getting used to that.” She signed off on all the necessary changes they had outlined. “Did you ever have this much trouble with my mom?” She couldn’t help but ask.

Arbor smiled with relief to have everything they needed for the audit secured, and adjusted their glasses. “Truth be told, she dreaded these meetings too.”

Glimmer chuckled at that. It was hard to imagine her stuffy mother getting upset with this in her Queenly, graceful way. If she did, she never mentioned it to Glimmer.

“Wait, what time is it?”

“Uh,” Bow checked his watch “Wow. Already 5:25. Time flies when you’re staring down pie charts, huh?”

“I’m going to be late!” Glimmer rushed out of the room in a poof of magic dust straight to the entrance hall of the castle.

“THERE you are!” Abner hissed under her breath, disappointed and worried about the kingdom’s appearance to guests. “You barely made it, he’s coming up the front steps now!”

“I’m totally ready!” Glimmer assured, straightening out her robes. She definitely did NOT look like a deranged mad-woman who had just spent several hours fighting for her life against a spreadsheet. Nope, totally put together.

The door behind her opened and Adora and Catra took their places by her side, each of them dressed impeccably and both standing much straighter than usual. Perhaps a little too precise? Glimmer looked them both over and quickly realized the tense air of competition between them. She rolled her eyes as Madame Rosemary herself came through the same room to stand in the corner and observe their Queenly behavior, looking distraught.

“Did you guys break Madame Rosemary?” Glimmer whispered in disbelief as Abner opened the front door for their guest. “I didn’t think that was possible…”

They did not have time to respond, as soon the young prince in a flashy sash was deeply bowing before the three of them respectfully, followed by his entourage of guards and attendants.

“Your Majesties.” He said with a polite smile. “It is an honor to meet the triumvirate rulers of Brightmoon.”

Glimmer smiled, and feeling more pressure to remember her princess training now that Madame Rosemary was there to see her in action, responded in equal fashion with a curtsy.

"The honor is ours, Prince Aurulius. May our realms grow stronger together." Nailed it. But in her mind, all she could think was *wait, what's a liquidity ratio?!*

Adora looked proud of her wife. Meanwhile, Catra silently mouthed 'NERD' to them.

Then, it was Adora's turn, and best believe it was BY. THE. BOOK. Her bow was deep and in perfect posture, and her pronunciation? Flawless!

"We are delighted by your presence, your highness. May our alliance be prosperous and enduring." She stood up straight again to glance over to Madame Rosemary in the corner. She looked *pained* but approving. Adora beamed. Gold star: secured.

Then it's Catra's turn. She could play it straight, but where was the fun in that? What would they do, fire her as Queen? She leaned into her performance with an over dramatic bow, followed with overly-articulate speech that drips with sarcasm masked as elegance.

“Ah, *Your Illustrious Radiance* , bearer of many sashes and serial vowels. May your verbal circus find harmony in our hallowed halls.”

Glimmer choked on a laugh so hard that it brought tears to her eyes. Adora side eyed Catra so hard, her eyes may have gotten stuck like that.

The prince however, simply nodded, unsure if it was a poetic beat or perhaps the way of the people of Brightmoon.

They moved to supper, and the air was tense with expectation. Prince Aurulius was from a very polished, very tradition-focused kingdom. And now, he could test this new alliance and see if the Queens could conduct themselves with appropriate regal dignity.

They sat to discuss trade and culture.

“Actually, we have restructured our infrastructural spending in anticipation of resource diversification.” Glimmer smiled, using just one of the fiscal facts she had earned after possibly trauma bonding with a castle accountant. The prince nodded, impressed. A solid win!

Adora didn’t spill a single thing, which she saw as a victory. When she picked up the wrong fork, Catra silently swapped it out for her without anyone noticing, and smirked.

Of course, they still bickered under their breath.

"Sashes? Really?" Adora whispered to Catra while the Prince was distracted.

"It's literally his whole thing!" Catra whispered back.

"If you two start a tongue-twister duel again I *will* leave." Glimmer whispered threateningly through her mask of a perfect Queenly smile.

But of course, from the outside to any other onlooker, they looked like the unshakeable, powerful if not somewhat eccentric trio of rulers who balanced each other out perfectly. Which in a way, they all did. Catra, for all her competition and mischief, still had the perfect sneaky movements to catch her wives in a slip and help them recover. Glimmer, for all that she had endured with the spreadsheets, could handle the talking. And Adora, who's chivalry knew no bounds, was sure to impress.

As the meeting drew to an end, the Prince bowed deeply again to them.

"Your kingdom is… uniquely vibrant." He smiled politely, somewhat amused. "I look forward to working with you all more."

They thanked him repeatedly, escorted him out again, and as soon as the door shut, they all sighed in tremendous relief. Glimmer slid down into her chair with a tired groan.

"If I have to look at one more pie chart, I'm going to throw it into the sea." She swore.

"Madame Rosemary smiled! I think it was a smile…" Adora chuckled.

"Honestly, the things I do for my wives." Catra smiled, coolly observing her nails. "I deserve a cookie."

They all laughed, sharing their exhaustion and affection in the light bubbly sound that floated easily between them. They had survived the day, their first official day back home from their honeymoon. And, despite all odds, had found a way to be Queens AND be themselves.

End Notes

Meanwhile Angella is chilling somewhere with a margarita like "not my problem any more lmao"

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!